Uzbekistan was the only country whose integrity towards supporting the UF was being doubted by India. Worried about the Islamist Movement of Uzbekistan (IMU) and under Moscow's influence, the Uzbeks supported the Almaty Conference and advocated military activism against the Taliban if needed. However, by the early 2000s, when the Taliban seemed firmly rooted in Afghanistan and was also getting diplomatically involved in other regional processes like the six plus two dialogue, the Uzbeks 'started changing their mind'.[122] According to X, Pakistan and the Taliban must have given 'silent guarantees that they will keep the IMU in control if Uzbekistan stops its support to Massoud'.[123] Indeed, in mid-2000, Uzbekistan started asking most UF leaders to leave their country and seek refuge elsewhere. However, these aspects of Pakistan's links with Uzbekistan require further evidence. What was clear, nonetheless, was that the stage to isolate Pakistan in the region was set, and as Saikal put it, 'Islamabad's support for Taliban has driven the Pakistan government into a cul de sac as the entire region has ganged up on the side of the ousted Afghan government'.[124] Even China, the alleged 'all-weather' friend of Pakistan, urged Islamabad to curb the Taliban's ambitions.[125] By mid-1997, barring the three supporters, no other country agreed to diplomatically recognise the Taliban.

Regional advocacies on Afghanistan had decisively shifted in favour of the partisans in 1996. The UNSC Resolution 1076 reflected the international community's aversion to the Taliban. Nonetheless, with its hands full with various other conflicts in the region, the UN failed to broker peace in Afghanistan. This post-Cold War context of weak nation-states struggling to consolidate legitimate power lent credence to the partisans' coercive diplomacy. Despite calls for peaceful resolution of the Afghan civil war, the Taliban's entry antagonised the region barring a few countries. For India, which had till now treaded a defensive diplomatic path, any idea of political accommodation of the Taliban became problematic. Given its regional interests, rivalries, and aspirations, keeping on good terms with Iran, the CIS, and Russia became a priority for New Delhi. Realising that the ISI was running training camps for the HM in Khost and Nuristan to foment Kashmiri insurgency, New Delhi adopted an active counter-insurgency approach domestically and sought strategic (anti-